The way Lara moved fields around, and played in-to-out shots from the rough against the spin, was touched by genius. Plenty of observers said nice things about me, as a certainty to play for the senior England team, after I scored 89 in a twenty-nine-run defeat, but watching him made me realize how far I had to go.

Of the current crop, Jos Buttler has Lara's ability to make you watch and wonder how he manages it. He radiates positivity in everything he does, a state of mind that transfers easily across to his batting. There is never a hint of indecision; he plays with an unforced confidence that tells bowlers, of the highest quality, that they are in trouble.

Speaking of quality bowlers, Jimmy Anderson is the most skilful I have seen. He is not one of those who can blast a tail out. He doesn't generate a fear factor, though he reaches 90 mph, and rarely picks up easy wickets. People think of him as a seam bowler, a deliverer of good old-fashioned line and length, but he is more, much more, than that. He might not be able to bat, but he is possibly the best cricketer England has ever produced.

His versatility, diligence and accuracy, aligned to his game intelligence, have enabled him to evolve as a player while remaining effective at the highest level. He can swing it and reverse it, and has mastered the art of wobble seam, initiated by Australia's Stuart Clark, who took twenty-six wickets at an average of 17 in his debut Ashes series, in 2006–07.

Clark could make the ball dart about on the most insipid pitch, by releasing it so that the seam wavered from side to side, rather than slicing through the air in an upright fashion. It involved widening the fingers on the grip, and aiming the ball so that it pitched on the edge of the seam. The subsequent movement was unpredictable and often deadly.

As so often, the difference between recognizing potential for improvement and actually realizing it is sheer hard work. Jimmy practised wobble-seam constantly, over a couple of years, until it became second nature. He saw how Mohammad Asif of Pakistan profited from a similar technique before his downfall in 2010, and had the open mind needed to make small, subtle alterations.

On overseas tours, for the past six or seven years, he has consistently worn down batsmen with an uncanny ability never to miss his length. That might not generate immediate reward, but his precision tests patience, erodes mental discipline. It is not untypical for Jimmy to pick up three